

Japanese Writing Systems

Study cards for beginners



Kanji 漢字

Chinese-origin characters that represent meaning. About 2,000-3,000 in common use.

EXAMPLE

一

ichi

(one)

二

ni

(two)

三

san

(three)



あ

Hiragana ひらがな

46 phonetic characters, one per sound. Curved, flowing strokes.

EXAMPLE

あ

a

い

i

う

u

え

e

お

o



Katakana カタカナ

46 phonetic characters, mainly for foreign loanwords. Angular, straight strokes.

EXAMPLE

テレビ

terebi

(television)



Roomaji ローマ字

Japanese sounds written with the English alphabet. 101 sounds total: 5 vowels, 95 consonant-vowel combinations, plus 'n'.

EXAMPLE

paatii

(party)

sofaa

(sofa)

chesu

(chess)

Roomaji Syllables Chart

Basic syllables (a / i / u / e / o) and contracted yōon sounds (ya / yu / yo)

Seion (Plain Sounds)

	a	i	u	e	o
k	ka	ki	ku	ke	ko
s	sa	shi	su	se	so
t	ta	chi	tsu	te	to
n	na	ni	nu	ne	no
h	ha	hi	fu	he	ho
m	ma	mi	mu	me	mo
y	ya		yu		yo
r	ra	ri	ru	re	ro
w	wa				

a	u	o
kya	kyu	kyo
sha	shu	sho
cha	chu	cho
nya	nyu	nyo
hya	hyu	hyo
mya	myu	myo
rya	ryu	ryo

Dakuon & Handakuon (Voiced Sounds)

	a	i	u	e	o
g	ga	gi	gu	ge	go
z	za	ji	zu	ze	zo
d	da			de	do
b	ba	bi	bu	be	bo
p	pa	pi	pu	pe	po
n	<i>n (consonant only)</i>				

a	u	o
gya	gyu	gyo
ja	ju	jo
bya	byu	byo
pya	pyu	pyo

Long Vowels 長音

Double vowels replace macrons for a long vowel sound (held twice as long). Vowel length changes meaning.

EXAMPLE

koohii

(coffee)

tori

(bird)

toori

(street)

Hyphens

Mark word boundaries: after prefixes/before suffixes, between compound words, and before inflected endings.

EXAMPLE

o-cha

(tea)

Nihon-go

(Japanese language)

iki-mashoo

(let's go)

Apostrophes

Mark a short pause after the 'n' sound, or show a contraction.

EXAMPLE

gen'in

(cause)

fun'iki

(atmosphere)

'N' Sound

Pronounced like 'm' before b/p/m, like 'ng' before g/k, and as a nasal sound before vowels, y/w, and s/sh/h.

EXAMPLE

shinbun

(newspaper)

kangae

(thought)

funsui

(fountain)

denwa

(telephone)

Double Consonants 促音

Sounds that merge together are shown by doubling the consonant.

EXAMPLE

hakkiri

(clearly)

massugu

(straight)

kitte

(stamp)

issho

(together)

Abbreviations

Notation used in this textbook for questions, answers, and examples.

EXAMPLE

Q

(question)

A

(answer)

S

(student)

T

(teacher)

e.g.

(example)

Vowels 母音

5 vowels (a, i, u, e, o), each clear and crisp -- shorter and more clipped than in English.

EXAMPLE

a

(father)

i

(king)

u

(put)

e

(pet)

o

(toe)

Voiceless Vowels

Between or after voiceless consonants (k, s, sh, t, ts, ch, h, f, p), 'i' and 'u' are pronounced weakly.

EXAMPLE

tsuki

(moon)

desu

(to be)

hisho

(secretary)

Semi-vowel Y 半母音 Y

A shorter, softer 'i' sound. Combines with a, u, or o as one syllable -- not two.

EXAMPLE

kyoo

(today)

kiyoo

(skillful)

Semi-vowel W 半母音 W

Only followed by 'a'. 'Wa' is pronounced like 'ua' without rounding the lips.

EXAMPLE

watashi

(I / me)

Consonants 子音

Followed by vowels, and lighter than in English. English 'l' and 'v' don't exist in Japanese. 'Z' doesn't vibrate at the tongue tip.

EXAMPLE

sh

(she)

ts

(wants)

f

(foot)

Japanese Pronunciation Guide

Japanese symbols and their English approximate pronunciation

Consonant Sounds

k *as in*
kind

ch *as in*
change

m *as in*
my

j *as in*
jumper

s *as in*
sound

n *as in*
knife

r *as in*
ring

d *as in*
dog

sh *as in*
she

h *as in*
hit

g *as in*
give

p *as in*
pink

t *as in*
tongue

f *as in*
foot

z *as in*
zone

b *as in*
big

ts *as in*
wants

Fu Sound

Made by protruding both lips, as if blowing out a candle.

EXAMPLE

fuyu

(winter)

R Sound

A flapping sound, made by quickly touching the tongue tip to the gum behind the upper teeth.

EXAMPLE

arigatoo

(thank you)

G Sound (mid-word)

Within a word, 'g' is close to the 'ng' sound, though this is optional.

EXAMPLE

eega

(movie)

shingoo

(traffic light)

kaigi

(conference)

Z Sound

Does not vibrate at the top of the tongue the way the English 'z' does.

EXAMPLE

mizu

(water)

Double Consonant Sounds

Doubled consonants (kk, ss, ssh, tt, tts, tch, pp) are pronounced with a brief held pause before release, like 'black cat' or 'hot tip' said quickly.

EXAMPLE

kitte

(stamp)

issho

(together)

hakkiri

(clearly)

Accent and Rhythm アクセント

Japanese uses pitch (high/low), not stress -- every syllable is the same length and speed, like a metronome that changes pitch. Same spelling with a different pitch pattern can mean something different.

EXAMPLE



a me

(candy)



a me

(rain)



se ki

(seat)



se ki

(cough)



ha ku shi

(doctorate)



ha ku shi

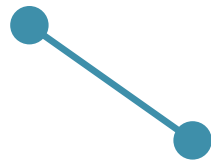
(white paper)

dot height = pitch (higher = higher pitch)



ai

love



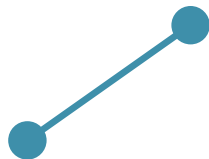
a

i



ie

house



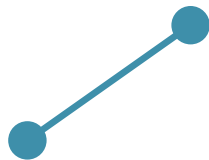
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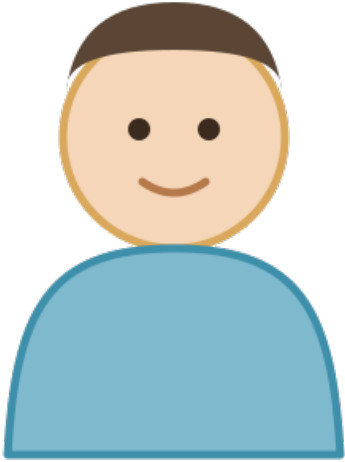
ue

above



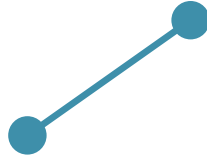
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e



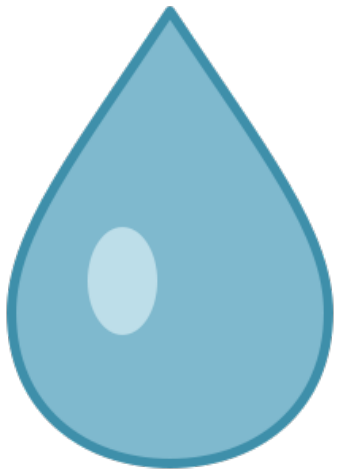
oi

nephew



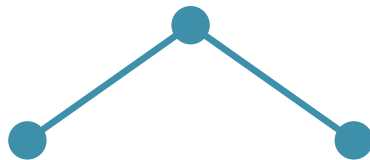
o

i



aoi

blue



a

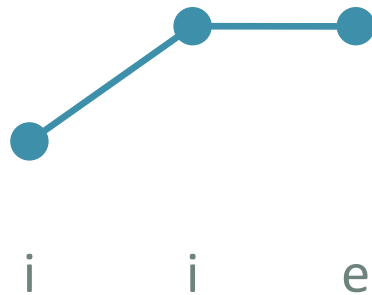
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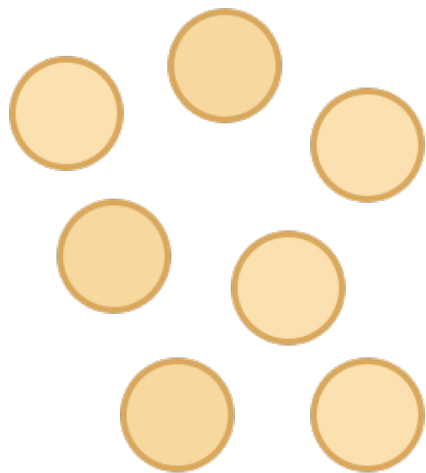
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iiē

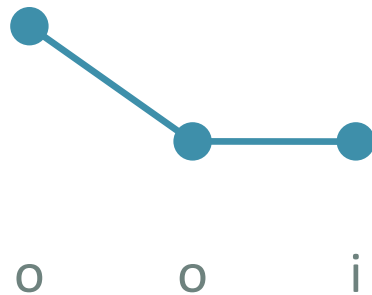
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ooi

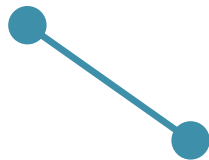
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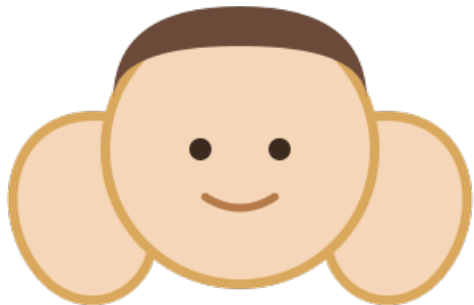
kaku

to write



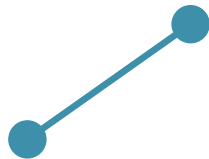
ka

ku



kiku

to listen



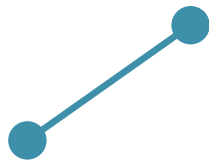
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ku



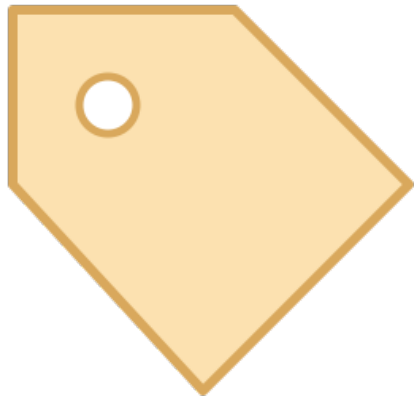
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here



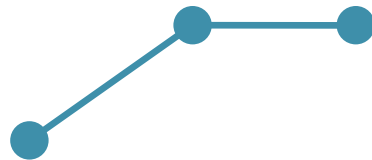
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ko



kakaku

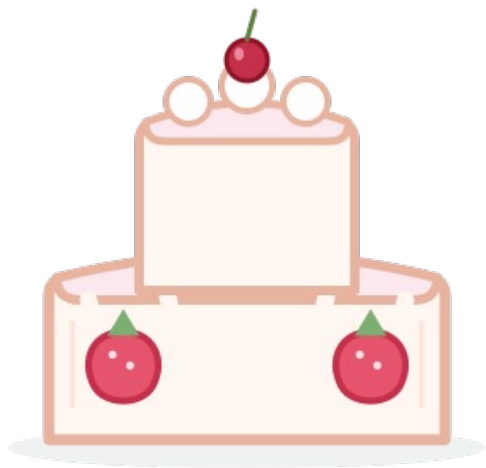
price



ka

ka

ku



keeki

cake



ke

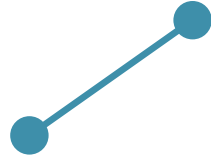
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ki



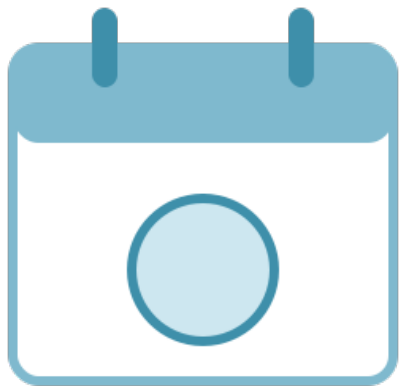
kyaku

customer



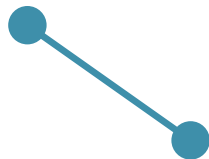
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ku



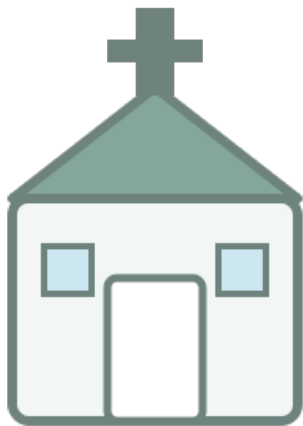
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today



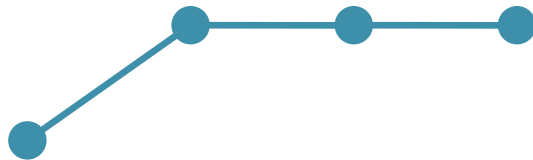
kyo

o



kyookai

church



kyo

o

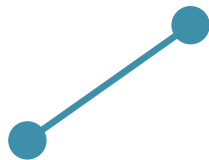
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saka

slope



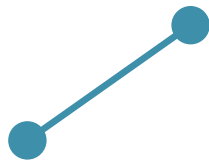
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ka



suu

to smoke



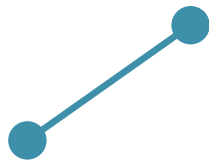
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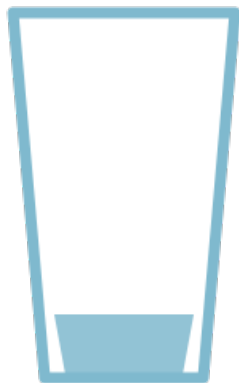
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there



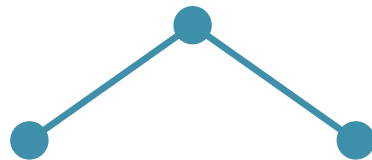
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sukoshi

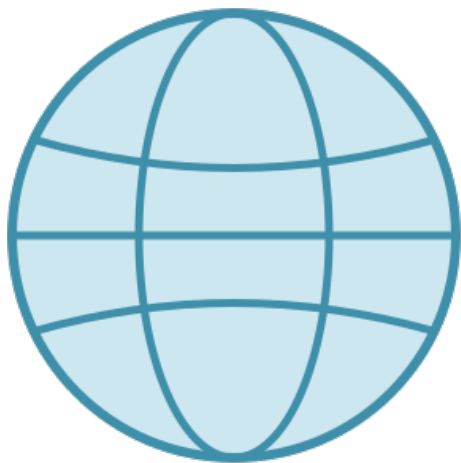
a little



su

ko

shi



sekai

world



se

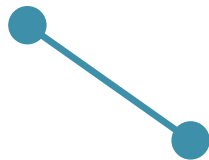
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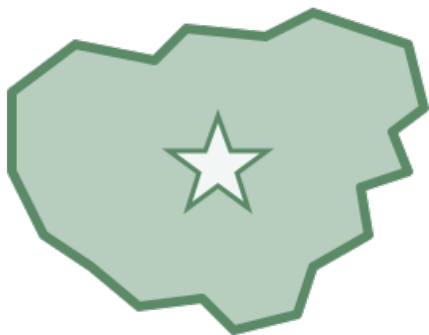
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garage



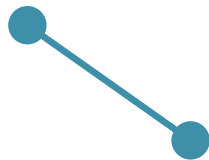
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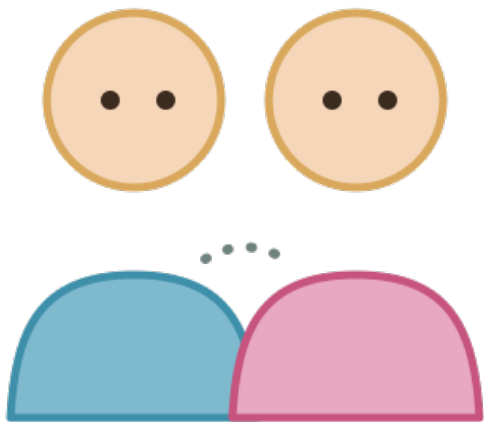
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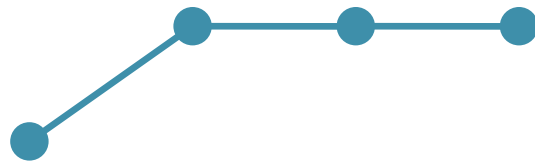
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shookai

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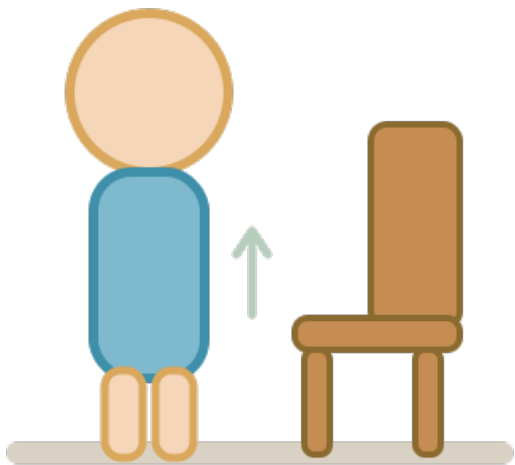


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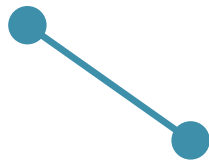
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tatsu

to stand



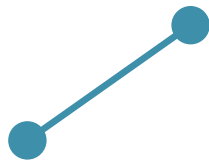
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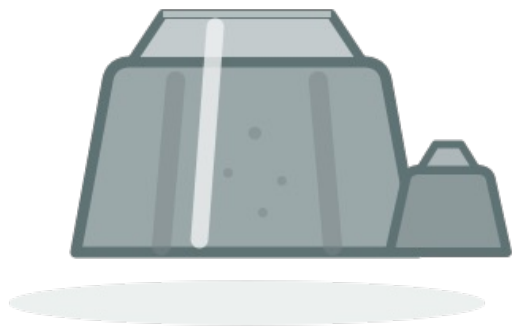
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dust



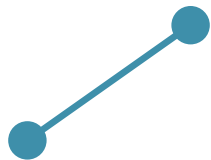
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iron



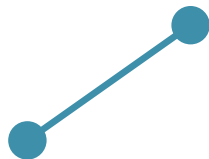
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toki

time



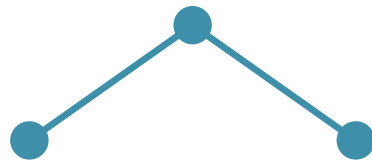
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chikai

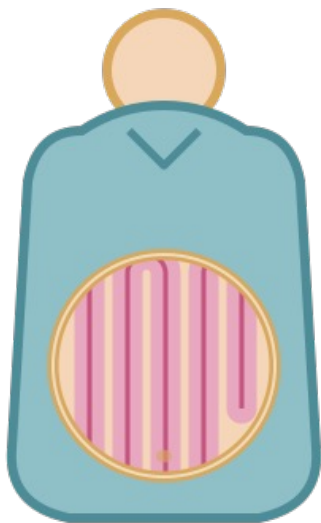
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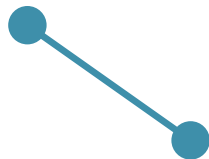
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choo

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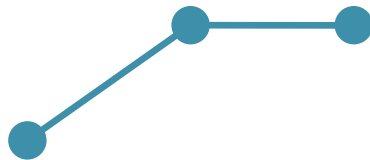
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chakuchi

landing



cha

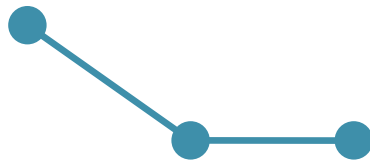
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chuucho

hesitation



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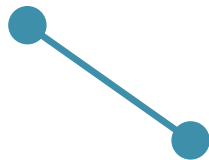
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nani

what



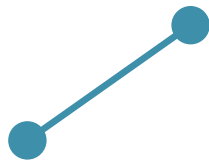
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ni



niku

meat



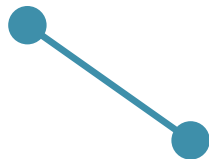
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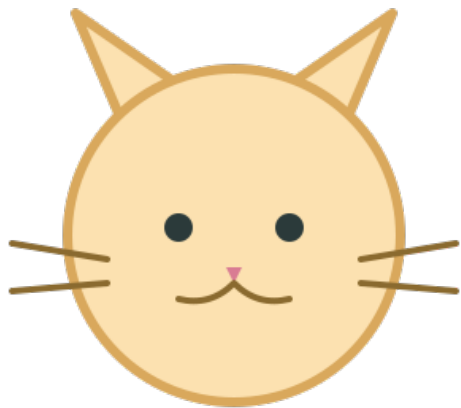
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to sew



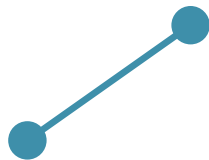
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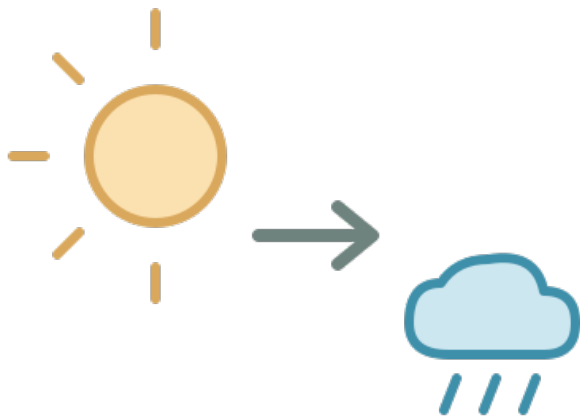
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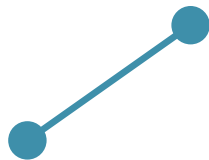
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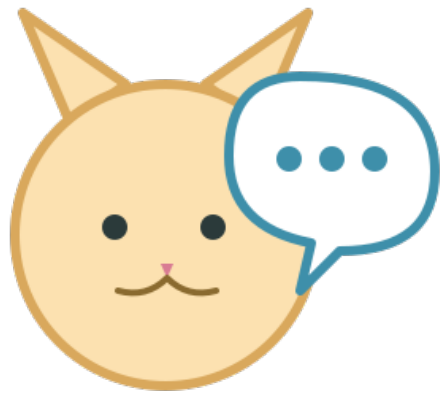
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later



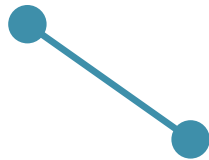
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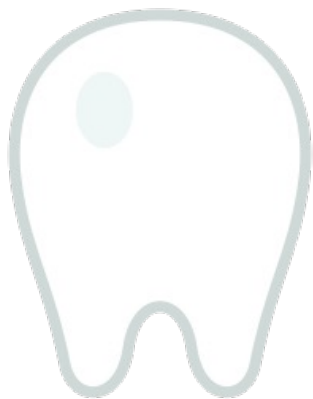
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meow



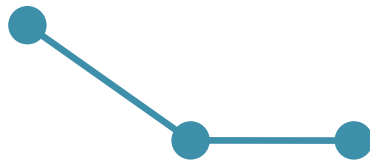
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a



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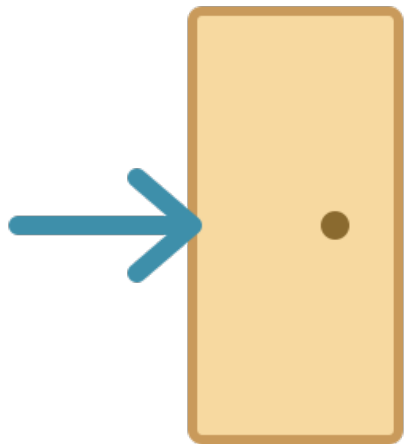
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nyu

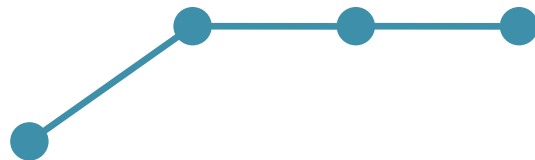
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shi



nyuukai

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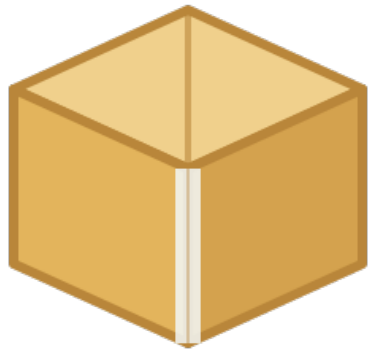


nyu

u

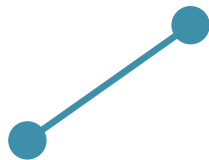
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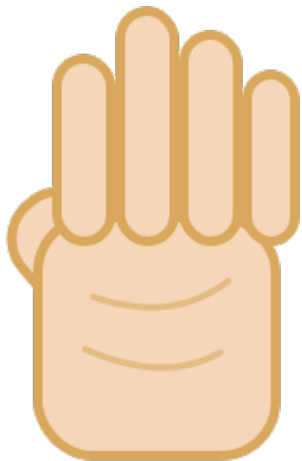
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box



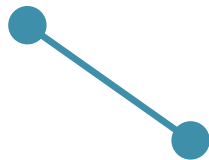
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hifu

skin



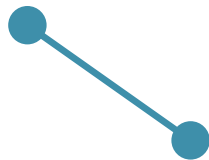
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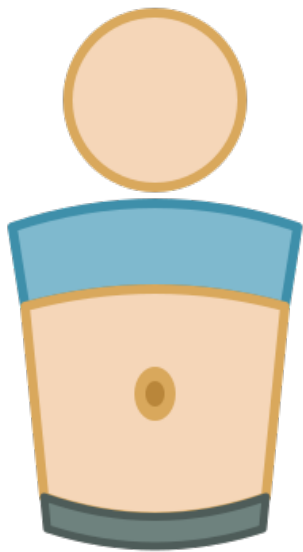
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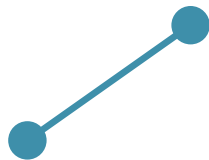
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navel



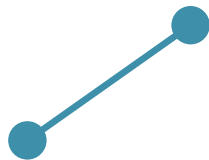
he

so



hoshi

star



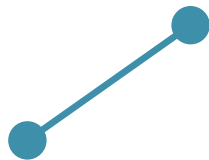
ho

shi



hyaku

hundred



hya

ku



hyuuhyu

whiz

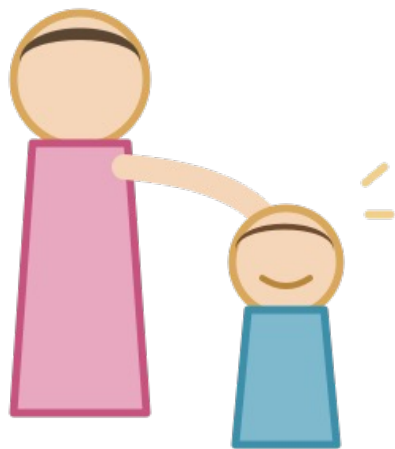


hyu

u

hyu

u



hyooka

valuation



hypo

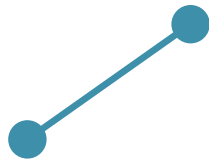
o

ka



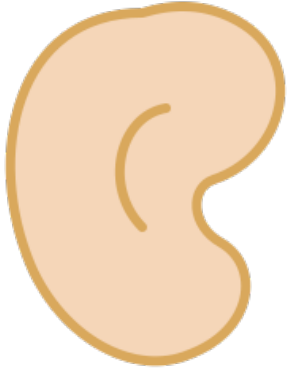
mame

bean



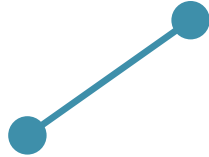
ma

me



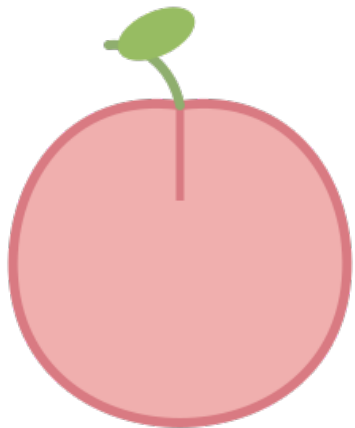
mimi

ear



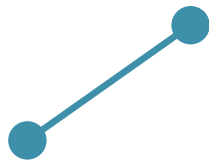
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mi



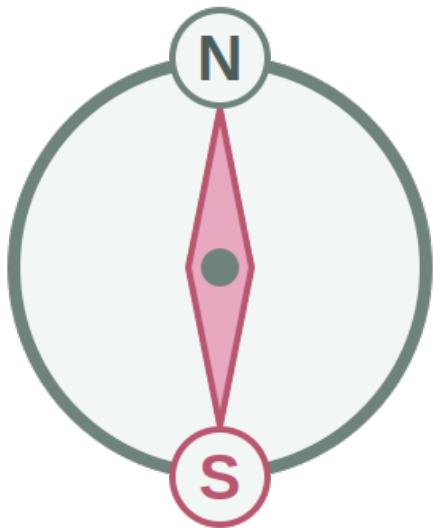
momo

peach



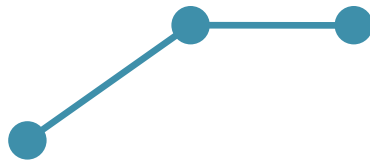
mo

mo



minami

south



mi

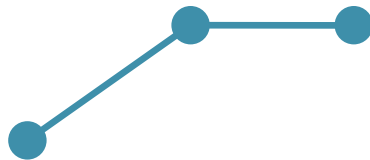
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mi



musume

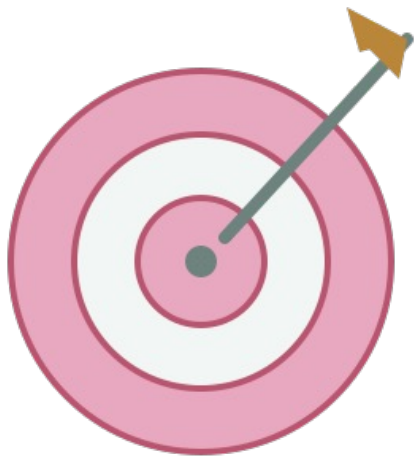
daughter



mu

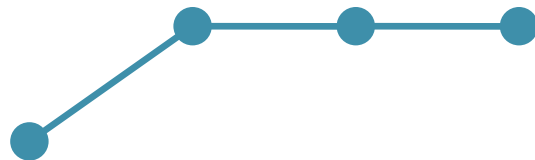
su

me



mokuhyoo

aim



mo

ku

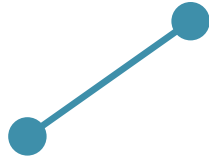
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o

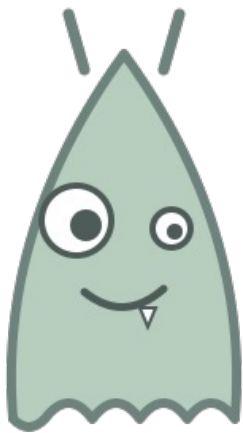


myaku

pulse

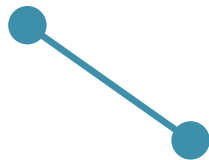


mya ku



myoo

odd



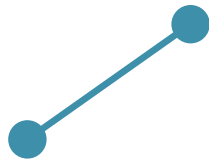
myo

o



yama

mountain



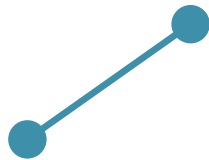
ya

ma



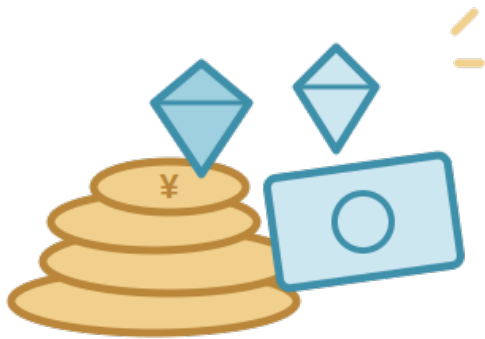
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dream



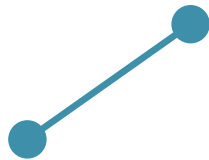
yu

me



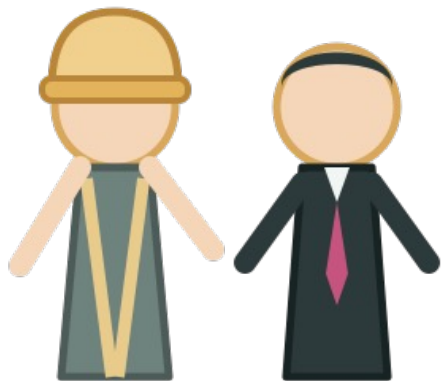
yoku

desire



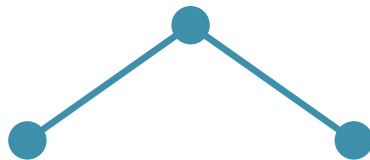
yo

ku



yatou

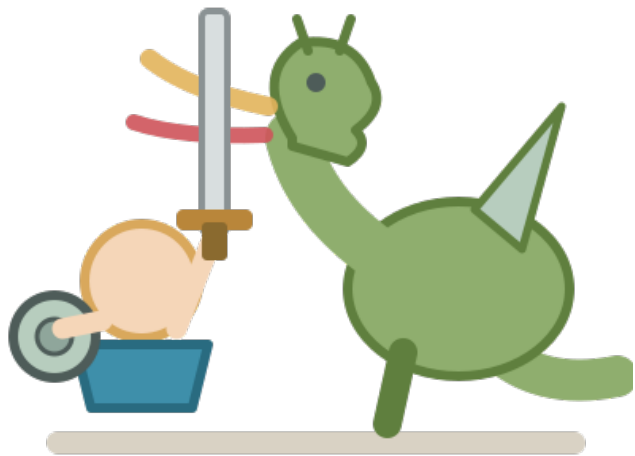
to employ



ya

to

u



yuuki

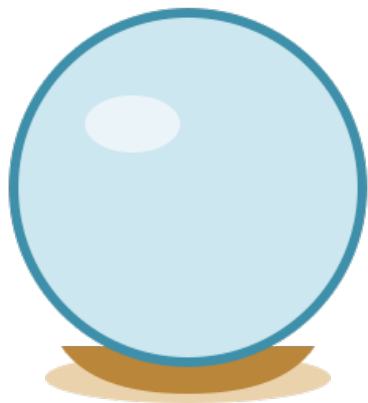
bravery



yu

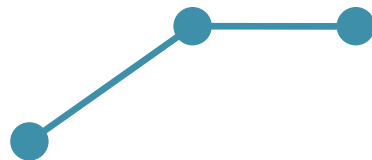
u

ki



yosoku

prediction



yo

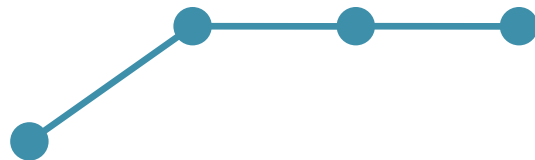
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ku



yuueki

profitable

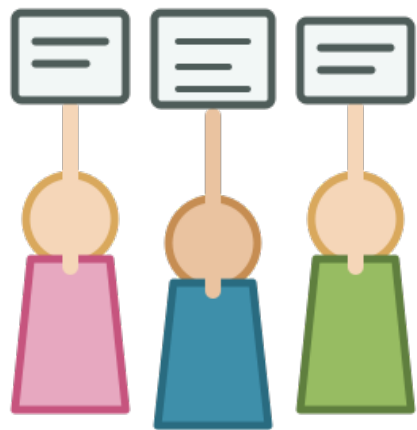


yu

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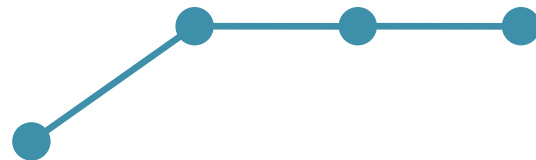
e

ki



yookyyuu

demand



yo

o

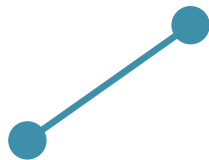
kyu

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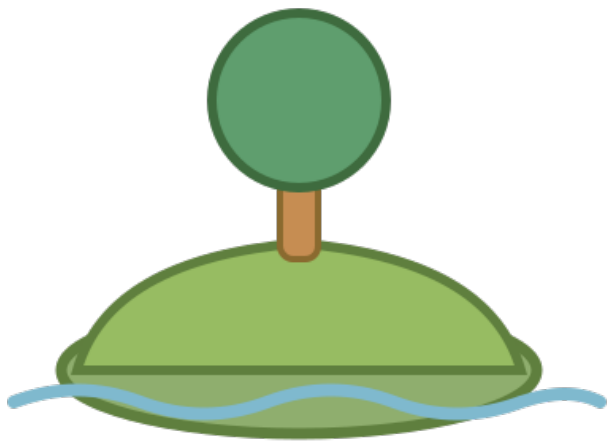
raku

easy



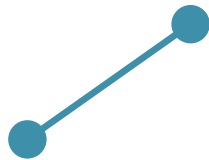
ra

ku



riku

land



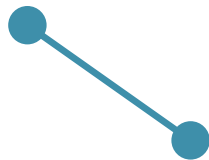
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ku



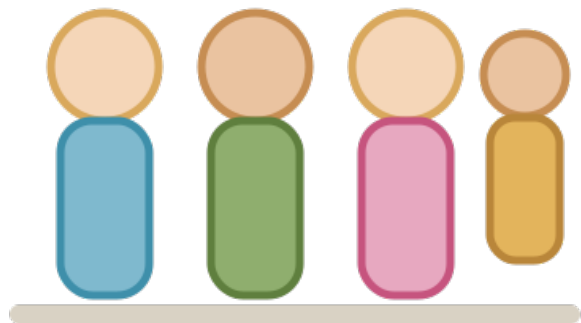
rusu

absence



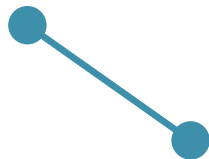
ru

su



retsu

line



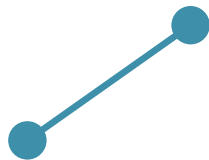
re

tsu



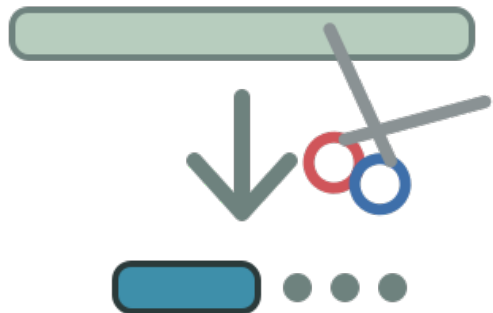
roku

six



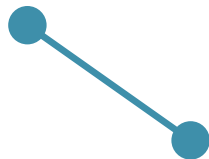
ro

ku



ryaku

omission



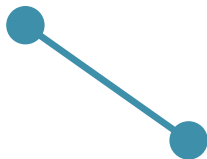
rya

ku



ryuu

dragon



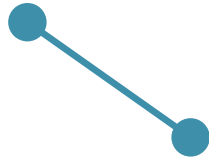
ryu

u



ryoo

amount



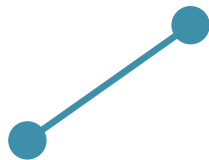
ryo

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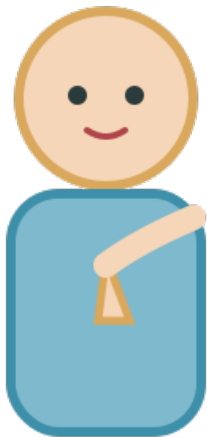
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eagle



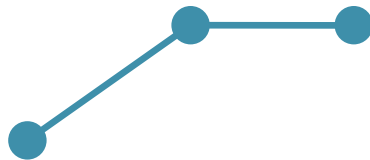
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shi



watashi

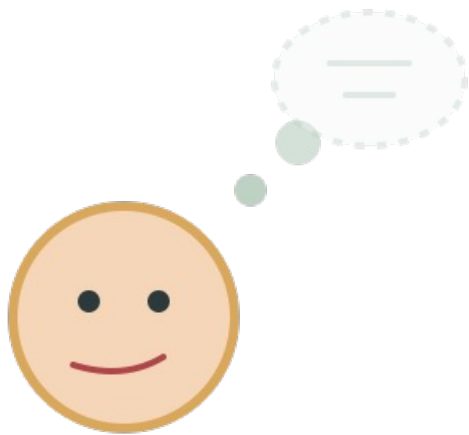
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wa

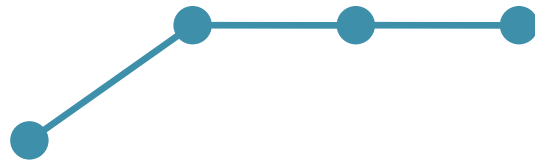
ta

shi



wasureru

to forget



wa

su

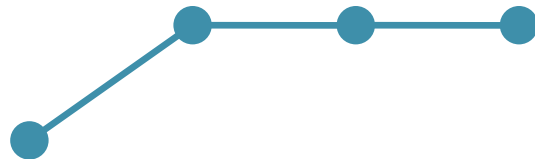
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ru



wariate

assignment



wa

ri

a

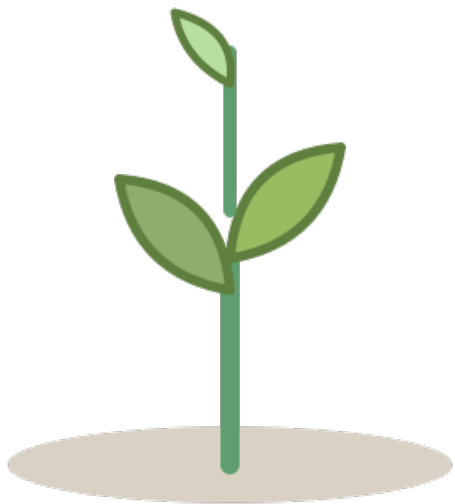
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wariateru

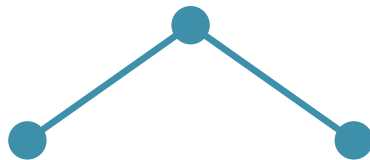
to allot





wakai

young



wa

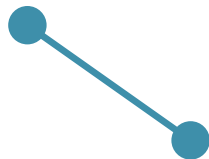
ka

i



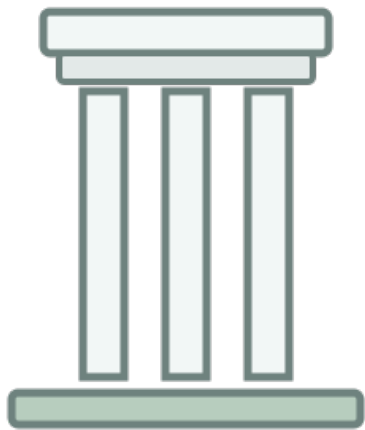
gai

harm



ga

i



girisha

Greece



gi

ri

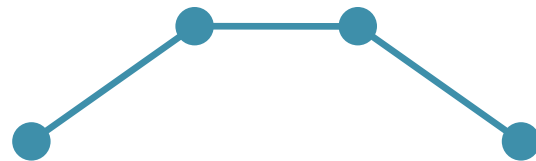
sha



2

guusuu

even number

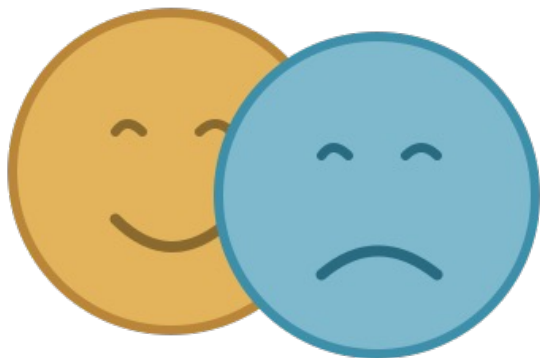


gu

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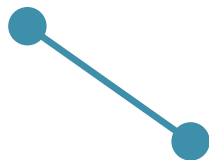
su

u



geki

drama



ge

ki



gogatsu

May



go

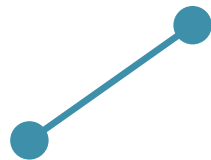
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tsu



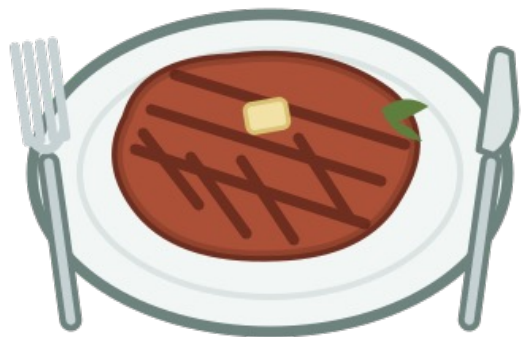
gyaku

contrary



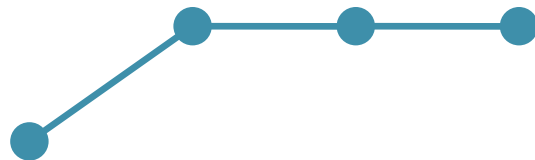
gya

ku



gyuuniku

beef



gyu

u

ni

ku



gyooji

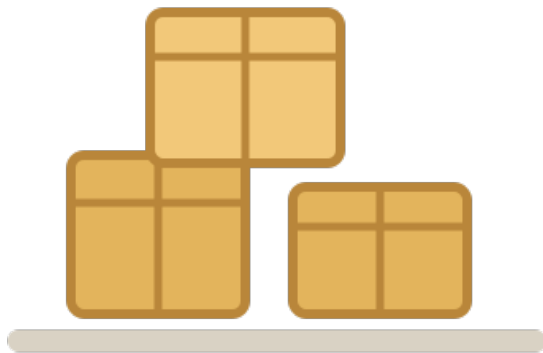
event



gyo

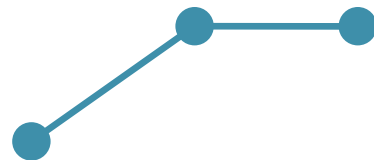
o

ji



zaiko

stock



za

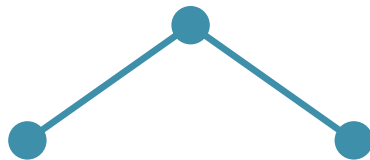
i

ko



jimusho

office



ji

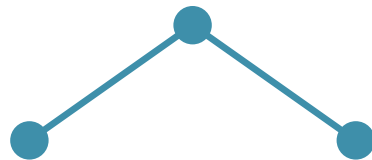
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sho



zurui

sly



zu

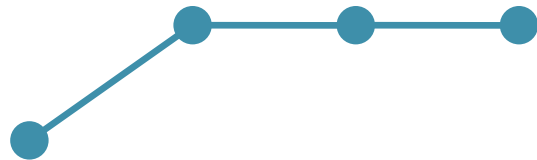
ru

i



zeetaku

luxury

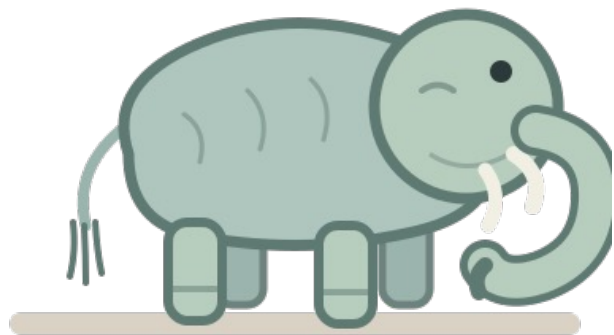


ze

e

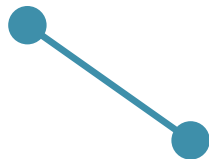
ta

ku



ZOO

elephant



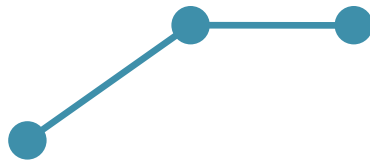
ZO

O



jaguchi

tap



ja

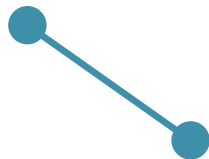
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chi



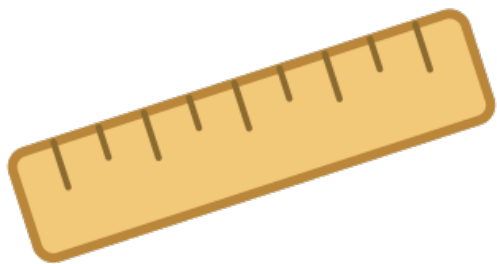
juu

ten



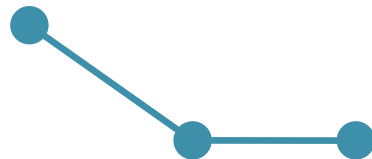
ju

u



joogi

ruler



jo

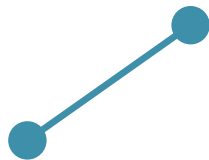
o

gi



dashi

soup stock



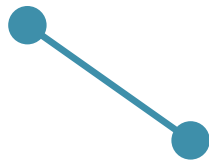
da

shi



deru

to go out



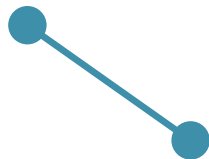
de

ru



doko

where



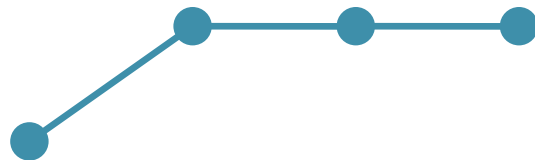
do

ko



daigaku

university

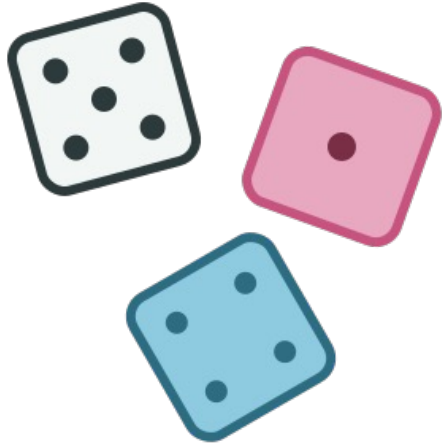


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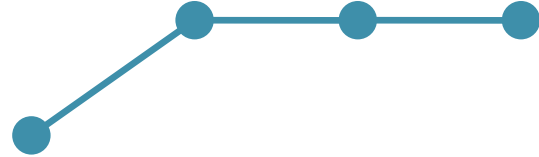
ga

ku



detarame

nonsense



de

ta

ra

me



doozo

please



do

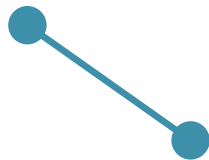
o

zo



batsu

punishment



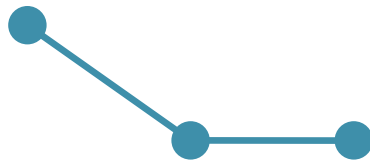
ba

tsu



biiru

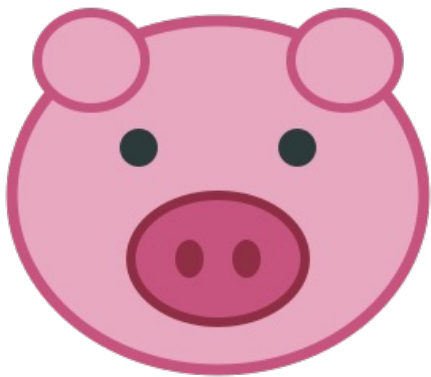
beer



bi

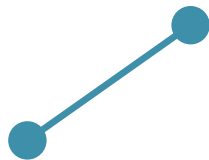
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ru



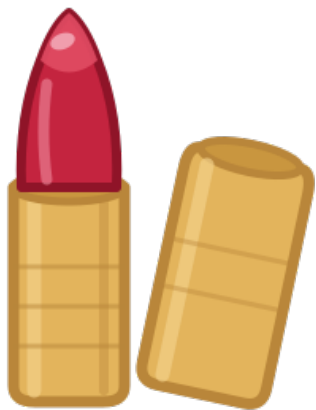
buta

pig



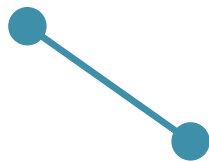
bu

ta



beni

rouge



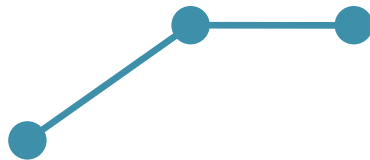
be

ni



booshi

hat



bo

o

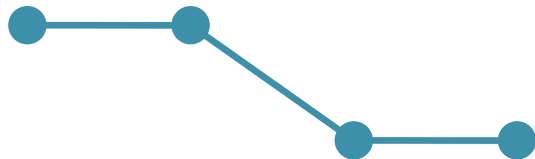
shi

300



sanbyaku

three hundred

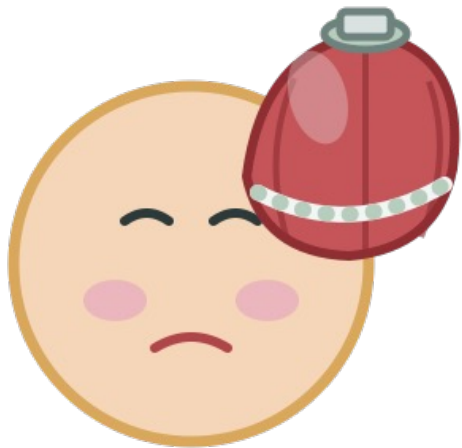


sa

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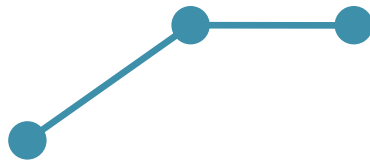
bya

ku



byooki

sickness



byo

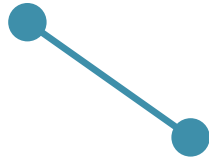
o

ki



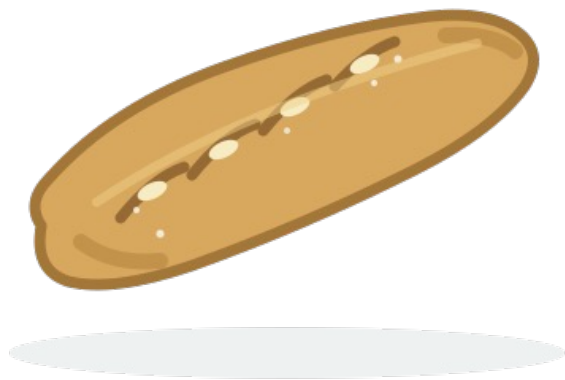
byoo

a second



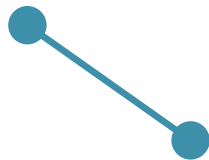
byo

o



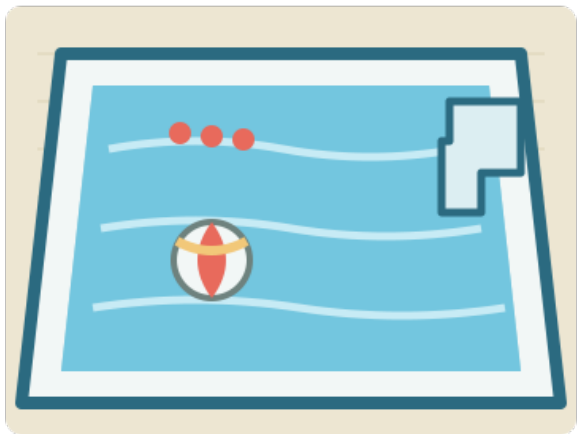
pan

bread



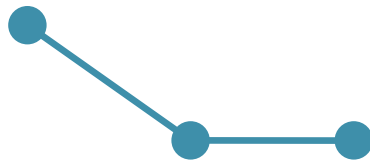
pa

n



puuru

pool



pu

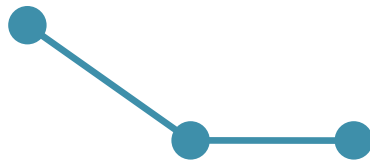
u

ru



posuto

mailbox



po

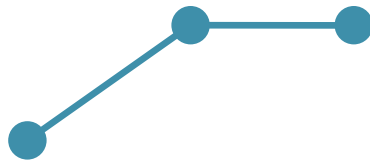
su

to



piano

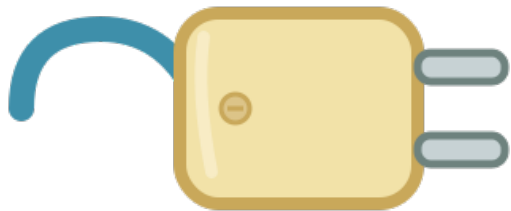
piano



pi

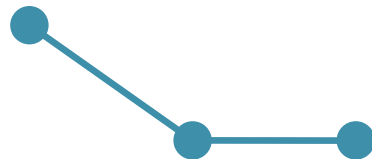
a

no



puragu

plug



pu

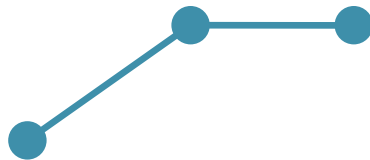
ra

gu



pedaru

pedal



pe

da

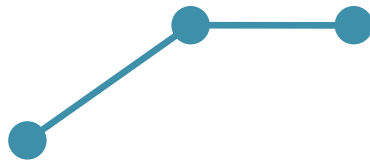
ru

600



roppyaku

six hundred



ro

ppya

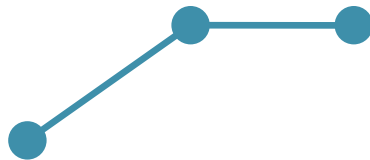
ku

800



happyaku

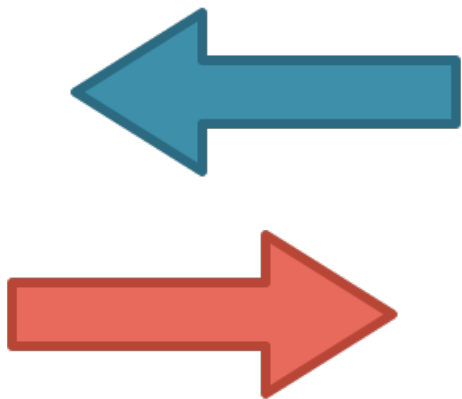
eight hundred



ha

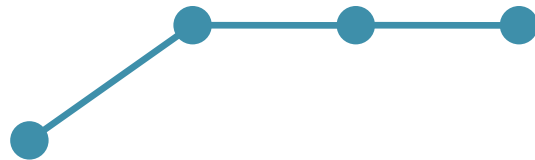
ppya

ku



hantai

opposite



ha

n

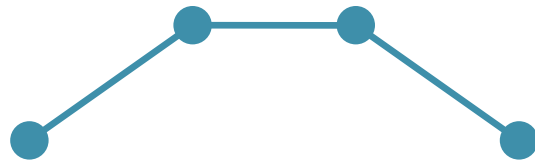
ta

i



bentoo

lunch box



be

n

to

o



kanri

administration



ka

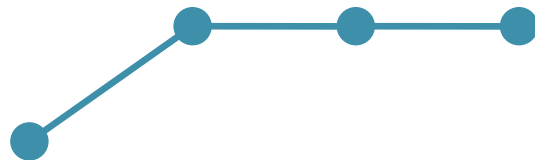
n

ri



hanzai

crime



ha

n

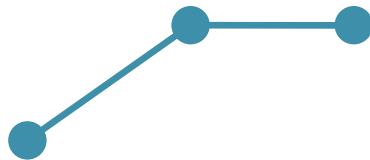
za

i



kanji

Chinese character



ka

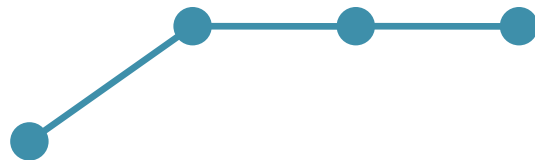
n

ji



kanpeki

perfect



ka

n

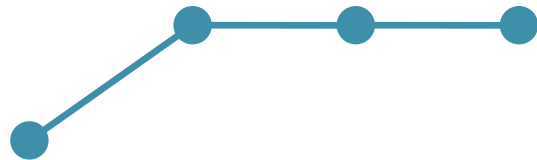
pe

ki



chinmoku

silence



chi

n

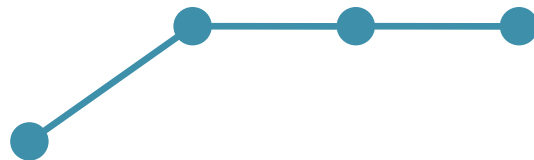
mo

ku



shinbun

newspaper



shi

n

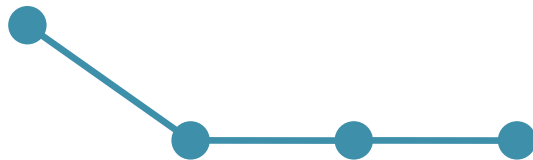
bu

n



konban

tonight



ko

n

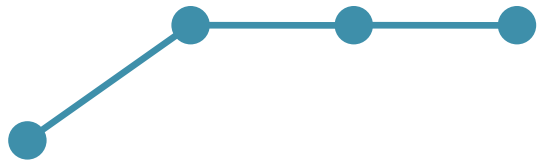
ba

n



kinpatsu

blond

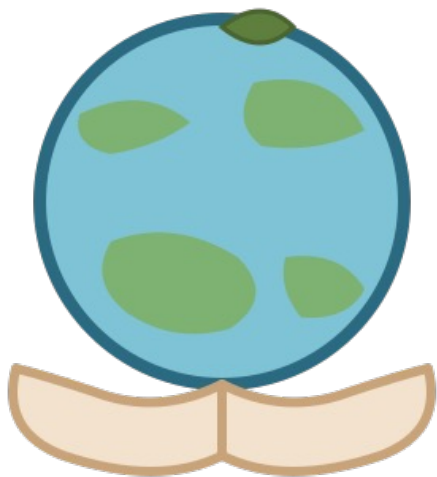


ki

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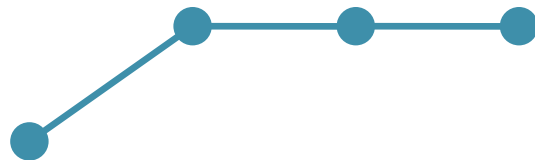
pa

tsu



kankyoo

environment



ka

n

kyo

o



tenki

weather



te

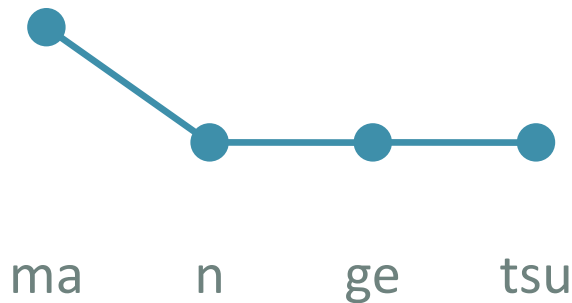
n

ki



mangetsu

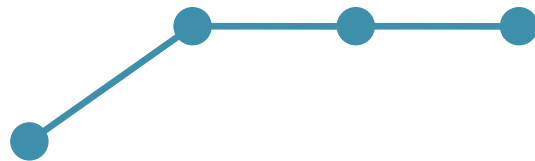
full moon





kenshin

devotion



ke

n

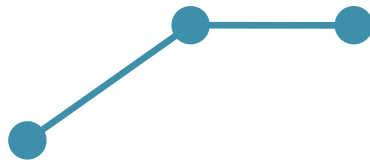
shi

n



denwa

telephone



de

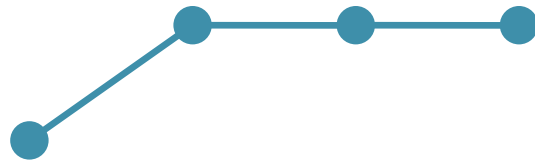
n

wa



tenin

clerk



te

n

i

n



honya

book store



ho

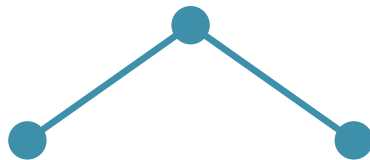
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ya



hakkiri

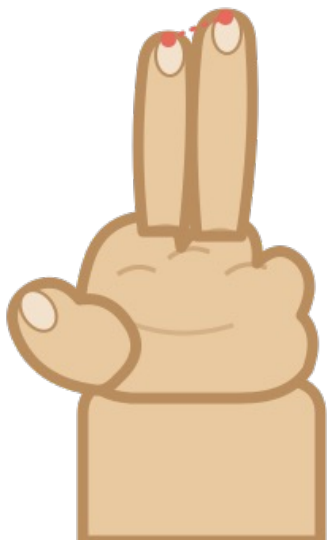
clearly



ha

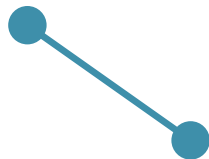
kki

ri



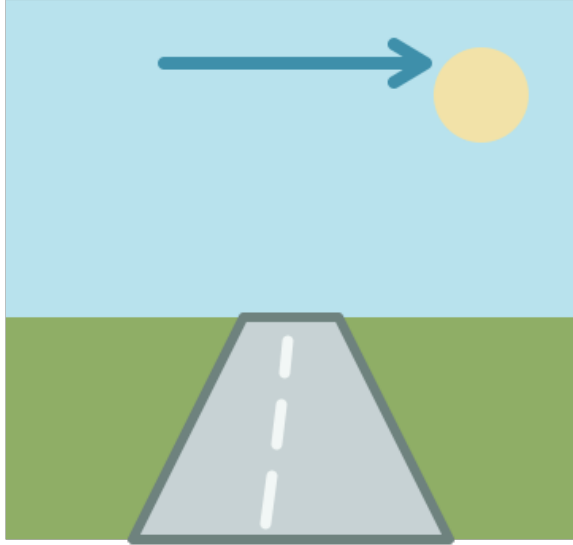
chotto

a little



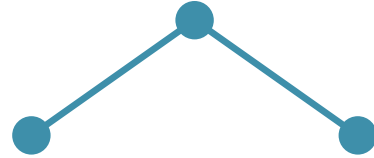
cho

tto



massugu

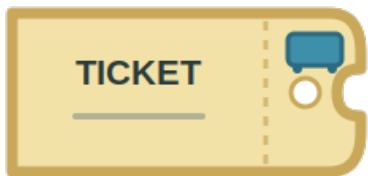
straight



ma

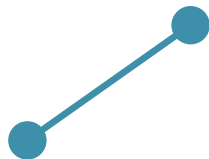
ssu

gu



kippu

ticket



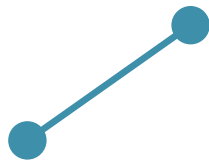
ki

ppu



kitte

stamp



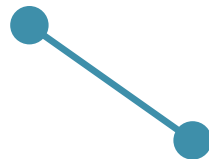
ki

tte



ame

rain



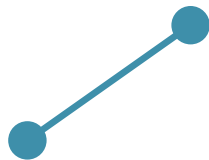
a

me



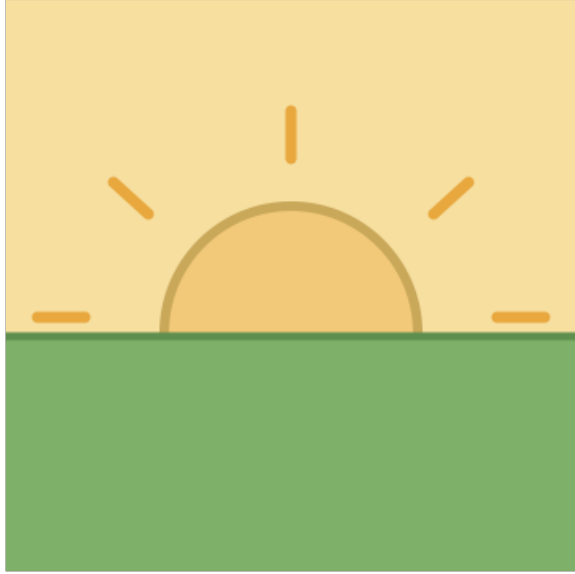
ame

candy



a

me



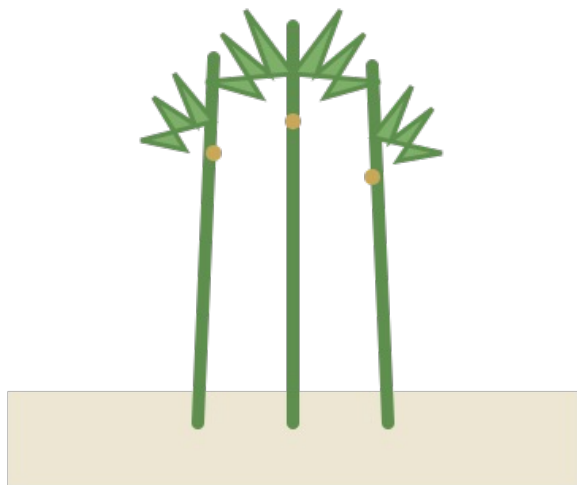
asa

morning



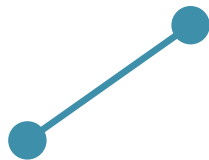
a

sa



asa

hemp



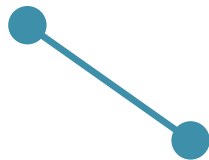
a

sa



seki

seat



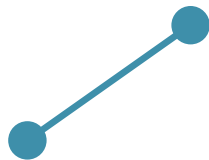
se

ki



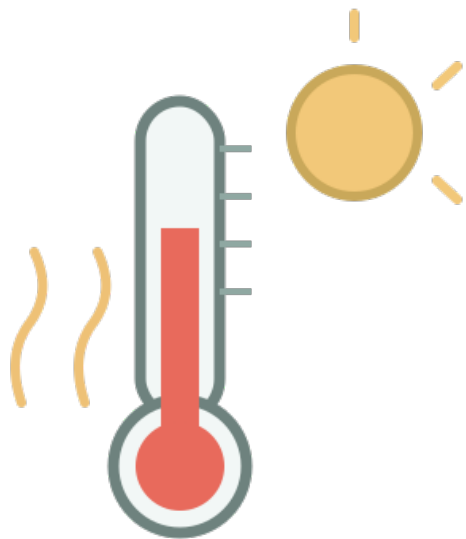
seki

cough



se

ki



atsusa

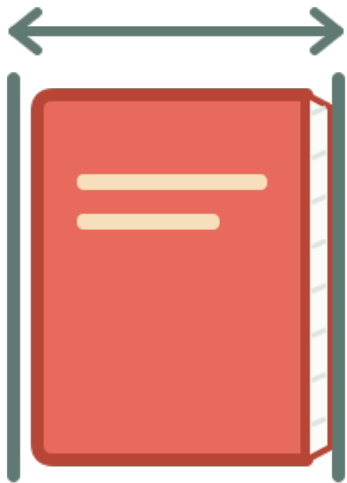
heat



a

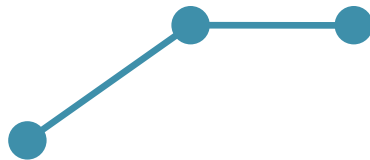
tsu

sa



atsusa

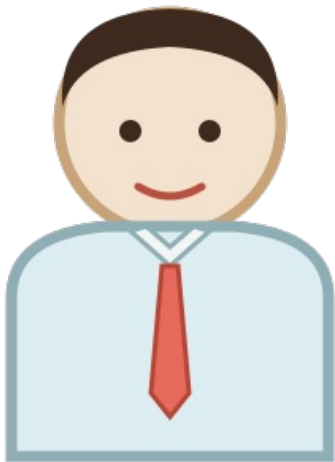
thickness



a

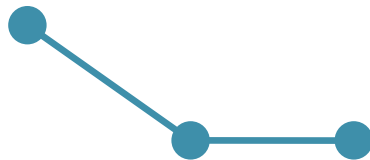
tsu

sa



shujin

husband



shu

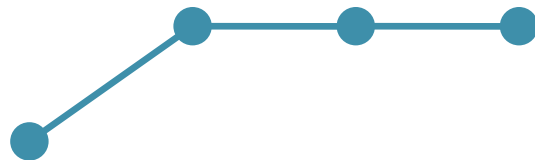
ji

n



shuujin

prisoner



shu

u

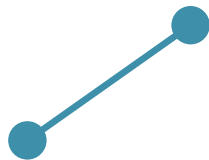
ji

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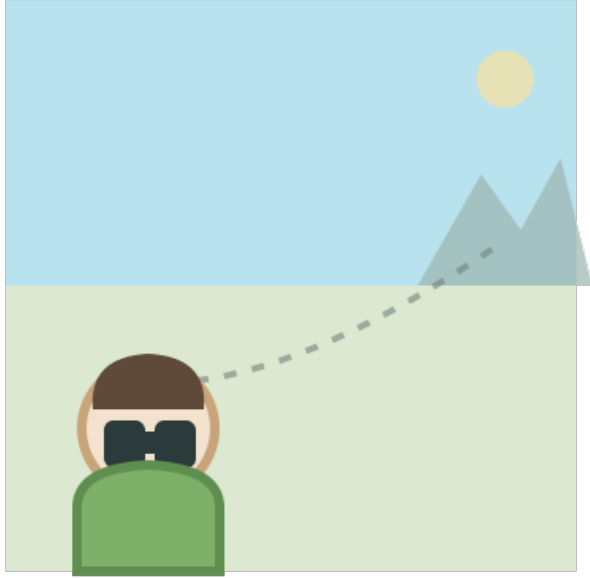
toi

question



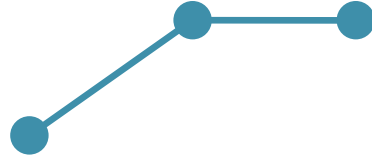
to

i



tooi

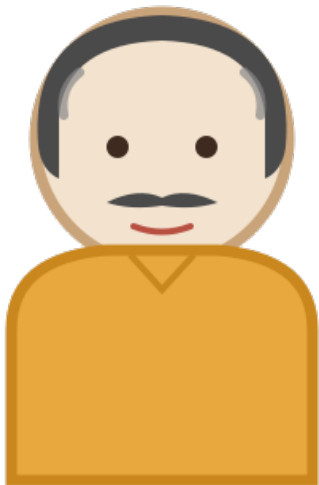
far



to

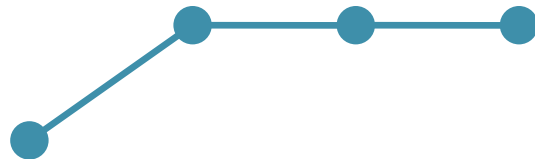
o

i



ojisan

uncle

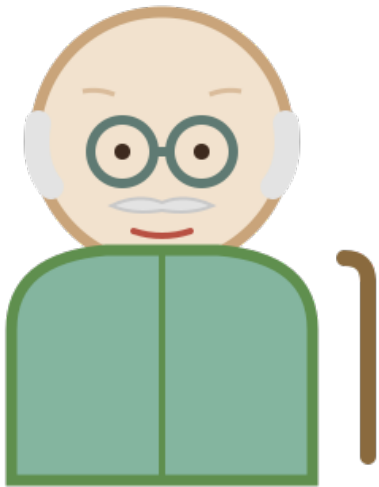


o

ji

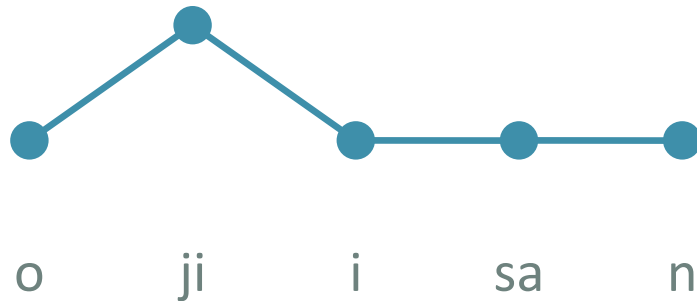
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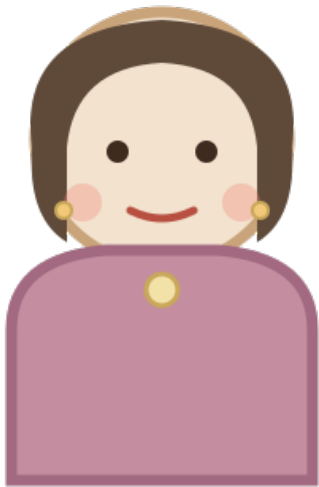
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ojiisan

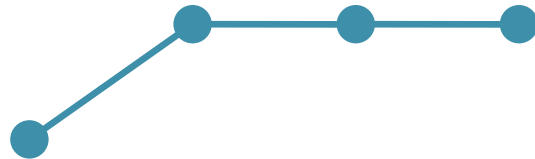
grandfather





obasan

aunt

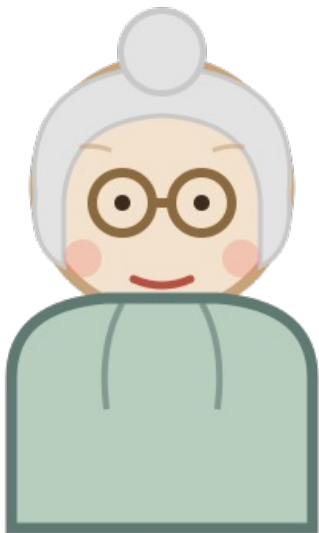


o

ba

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obaasan

grandmother

